An Extensive Commentary Called The Eye of Joy

Ānandacakṣu nāma ṭīkā · Toh 1201 · Derge Tengyur
དགའ་བའ་སེལ་ཆུ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་རི་རྒྱུར་འགལ་ཡེ་ས

The Eye of Joy, in Sanskrit Ānandacakṣu nāma ṭīkā and in Tibetan Gawé Chen zhé jawé Gyacher Drelpa, is an extensive commentary on the glorious Mahāmudrātilaka, the Tantra of the Drop of the Great Seal, a yoginī tantra that the commentary presents as a later tantra drawn from the vast Hevajra cycle. Its author, the Indian master Prajñāśrīgupta, a disciple of the Kashmiri scholar Ratnavajra in a lineage traced back to King Indrabhūti, explains the tantra's opening words, "Then the secret to be explained," on several levels of meaning, and through them sets out the six yogas, the generation and completion stages, the channels and syllables of the subtle body, and the four joys and four moments by which the joy of intrinsic nature is realized. He wrote it at the request of the Tibetan monk Rinchen Gyaltsen, and the two of them translated it into Tibetan together. It is Toh 1201 in the Tengyur, where it is found among the commentaries on the tantras, belonging to the class of works on the yoginī, or mother, tantras.

In the language of India: ānandacakṣu nāma ṭīkā. In the language of Tibet: An Extensive Commentary Called The Eye of Joy.

Homage to glorious Vajraḍāka.

Sovereign of all the kings of yoginī tantras,
Wondrous, most wondrous,
The glorious Tilaka, ocean of suchness:
To the one who spoke it, I pay homage.

As for the meaning of the verse "Then the secret to be explained," first: what fault is there in my writing down, as a reminder for myself, what I heard through the kindness of the lotus feet of the Kashmiri abbot Śrī Ratnavajra, the great scholar who received empowerment and pith instructions from the unbroken succession of accomplished gurus descending from the great king Indrabhūti, and the guru of the supreme king of the lords of kings? Or else: the excellent master Rinchen Gyaltsen, a monk born in Central Tibet, urged me, asking, "What are the ultimate generation stage and completion stage of the six yogas of the glorious Mahāmudrātilaka tantra like?" What fault is there in my writing it down just as it is, so as to explain it for his sake? For what reason should the learned feel aversion? Or else: since the blind, possessed of wrong

understanding, have utterly lost the path, in my giving them this Eye of Joy there is no fault, nothing but the purpose of good qualities.

Now I shall examine the meaning of what is said. The word "then" means "after that." The Lord of Victors, glorious Vajrasattva, the Blessed One, was dwelling in the abode of the joy of great bliss, whose essence is the union of intrinsic nature. From the midst of a retinue numbering seventy-two koṭis of vajraḍākinīs, the queen, glorious Mistress of Perfect Delight, made a request of him; and in response to her request, since the fruit of the nectar of gnosis had fully ripened, he spoke, from the tantra of glorious Hevajra, the ocean of gnosis in five hundred thousand verses, the wondrous secret of the glorious Mahāmudrātilaka, the later tantra, the supreme king of lords among the yoginī tantras.

Or else: in this tantra, the king of lords, the explanation of the ultimate consciousness of the six yogas, which comes after the two chapters, that on the tantra of all and that on empowerment, is the meaning of "after that." Therefore it is secret. Or else, it is secret because the śrāvakas and others have not found it. That the vajra verses, so hard to understand, are made clear by the later sequence: this is the meaning of "explained." The meaning is that the gnosis of the Dharma seal (dharmamudrā), whose intrinsic nature is joy, is found through various means. That is the literal meaning.

Now I shall explain the comprehensive meaning of all the limbs taught there. The supreme path, distinct from the Kriyā tantras and the rest, is characterized by the union of wisdom and skillful means: that is the meaning of "then." Through the limb of the balanced union of wisdom and means, through enjoyment, and through empowerment, to meditate within the center of the lotus at one's own heart on the form of the deity, with its body color, hand emblems, and the rest, in the stage of generation from moon, vajra, and seed syllable: that is the "secret." To meditate, in that deity form, on the wisdom seal (prajñāmudrā), the nondual aspect of the gnosis of great illusion: that is the meaning of "explained."

Now I shall explain the essential meaning of what was explained before. "Then" means after wisdom and means: having ripened, results such as the result concordant with the cause are found. This is because the supreme cause has the defining characteristics of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa. If one asks why it has the defining characteristics of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, it is because of the forms of the imputed and the other-dependent natures. It is other-dependent

because it arises in dependence on another; the word "other" means dependent origination. Thus too the Omniscient One (the Buddha) said:

Whatever is dependently arisen is not born.

It is imputed because it is devoid of its own essence. When analyzed in terms of one and many, the essential nature of external things is not found in the ultimate sense. Because it is not found, everything is of the nature of emptiness, like space.

It is not the way a pleasure-seeking person possessed of wrong understanding takes it, as nothing at all. If there were nothing at all, striving for the sake of liberation would bear no fruit. The roots of virtue and the rest, to be performed as meritorious action, would become meaningless; and since they would be meaningless, liberation would not be found. That is not reasonable. Even when conceptions such as generosity are found, it is likewise not something contrived. Accordingly, in the Completion Stage composed by the great master Śrī Ratnavajra, it says:

Because the accumulation of virtue is the cause,
It is the path of the Sugatas.
This liberation is not contrived;
Its defining mark is the gnosis of intrinsic nature.
Since it is found through merit, it is not born;
It is not born from that merit.

Likewise, by fully understanding wisdom and means, saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, the imputed and the other-dependent, and the results of maturation and of concordance with the cause, one finds the stainless perfected nature, but it is not born. Thus too, the Tattvasiddhi on the stages of the secret essence says:

Dwelling within the host of the senses,
Though the seeds of saṃsāra are not exhausted, there is no birth.
Through union with the difficult reality,
Equal to space, one thereby tastes coolness.

Likewise, the great master, the noble Nāgārjuna, has explained:

The full understanding of saṃsāra
Is what is called nirvāṇa.

The great king Indrabhūti has explained:

The full understanding of nirvāṇa:
That is gnosis, whose intrinsic nature is space.

The master Kilaripa has explained:

When existence and nirvāṇa are fully understood,
There is great bliss free of conceptual thought.

The master Koṅkana has explained:

In a mere instant of the purity of existence and nirvāṇa,
The incomparable is born.

And in the glorious Tantra of the Essence of All Yoginīs it is said:

Without arising and without cessation,
Free of continuum and example,
Without existence or nirvāṇa:
That is the incomparable, the great intelligence.

That is the meaning of "then." Without need of an external wisdom consort, by way of the wisdom of closing, opening, and so forth, the conventional awakening mind arises from the wisdom-gnosis whose own defining character is the fierce one (caṇḍālī): that is the "secret."

Its samaya seal (samayamudrā) of equipoise at the center of the root of the vajra, the assembly of gnosis: that is the meaning of "explained."

Now I explain the meaning of intrinsic nature. "Then" means that after the results of maturation and of concordance with the cause, the stainless arises through fully understanding them. It is not by casting them away. Because those two are present, the stainless is found by stopping the gnosis wind at the tip of the vajra jewel: that is the "secret." As soon as that is found, there is the essence of the aspect free of waves, in which no phenomenon is apprehended; and through the gnosis of the Great Seal (mahāmudrā), the intrinsic nature that follows the true, stainless supreme, one sees all things: that is the meaning of "explained."

Now I explain the meaning of each syllable, endowed with the joys and moments of the six yogas. In the passage beginning "At that time, too, the drop," the words "at that time, too" refer to time. Or else, "at that time, too" is a joining in time. What is joined with what? The two are joined: the syllable ta and the syllable ra. The syllable ta is the Holder, whose essence is wisdom and whose form is crushing (vimarda). The syllable ra is rasanā, the right channel,

whose essence is skillful means and whose form is maturation (vipāka). Because she joins them, the joiner, the Nonconceptual One, whose essence is vilakṣaṇa, dwells in the place of wind. The circle of wind extends from the navel to the soles of the feet. If one were to think otherwise, a great fault would arise. That is the connection.

The Holder, rasanā, and the Nonconceptual One do not go outside the heart of the secret lotus by even a thousandth part of the tip of a hair. And why do they not go outside? When six cakras are enumerated, where else would the channels and joys of the cakra of wind be located? Therefore it is the reasoned system that the principal site of the cakra of wind is the center of the secret lotus. That is the position of the completion stage. In the system of the generation stage, it is the cakra of great bliss, for it is the place from which everything arises, and it bestows the result.

In order to find the result, first meditate as follows. At the root of the navel is a wind maṇḍala, transformed from yaṃ, shaped like a bow and blue in color. Above it, from the transformation of raṃ, is a fire maṇḍala, triangular and red in color. As the wind is stirred, the luminous form of the blazing fire of gnosis in the navel lotus burns the Tathāgatas dwelling in the cakra of Dharma. Then, by the path of enjoyment, it settles in the cakra of great bliss at the opening on the inner threshold of the golden door, regarded as Oḍḍiyāna. With its own light it melts the nectar, and carrying that nectar, in a peaceful form, it fully satisfies those it burned before, and makes its dwelling in the navel lotus. From that, one comes to have a mind of great passion. One knows all phenomena as having a single nature. And one contemplates this intensely. That through which this occurs is the conventional meaning of "at that time, too."

"At that time, too" serves as the very near abode of the meaning that has divided into two. It also provides the cause for the manifest arising of drops. That is the arising of the syllable a through the union of channel and letter. Here, "arising" should be understood as "going": because the syllable a, whose essence is the awakening mind, always rides on the wind, it should be understood as going. As soon as it goes, the sign called "trembling" arises. From that sign the yogin knows the moment of variety (vicitra). As soon as this is known, the awakening mind present at the crown of the head goes to the place of the forehead. That comes through familiarization. Through familiarization, one knows samādhi without need of an action seal (karmamudrā). That is the meaning of the syllable a, endowed with the taste

of trembling and the moment of variety, in the awakening mind at the site of the cakra of great bliss.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable tha. The syllable tha is the "drop," because it has the form of the aspect of utmost bliss; or else, because of feeling. It too remains, fully distinguishing the meaning that has divided into two. It makes clear what arises from future maturation. It also provides the cause for the manifest arising of "mode." At that time the sign called "dust" arises. From that sign one knows the moment called maturation. That is the meaning of the syllable tha, located in the cakra of complete enjoyment, endowed with dust and maturation.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable tu. The syllable tu is "mode," because it arises by itself; therefore it is self-arisen. This is because it is free of a beginning. Because it is free of a beginning, it has no end either. Because it is free of a beginning, it has no middle either. Because it has no beginning, end, or middle, it is self-arisen. Or else, it is the mode of the self-arisen because the a entirely destroys the pitch darkness of delusion from which the latencies of ignorance arise. It remains, fully effecting the meaning that has divided into two. It makes clear the particulars of its own object. It also provides the cause for the manifest arising of "mere mode." From that the sign called "intoxication" arises. From that sign one knows the moment called crushing. That is because the awakening mind is at the site of the cakra of Dharma. That is the meaning of the syllable tu, located in the cakra of Dharma, endowed with intoxication and crushing.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable ra. The syllable ra is "mere mode." The word "mere" makes clear the meaning of being free of existence and nonexistence. The word "mode" indicates a thing whose nature as gnosis and so forth exists; the word "mere," a thing whose nature as gnosis and so forth does not exist, just like the moon in water. Therefore it is "mere mode." It remains, fully effecting the meaning that has divided into two. It brings about the touch that apprehends the particulars of its own object. It also provides the cause for the manifest arising of the "supreme." At that instant the sign called "unsupported limbs" arises. From that sign one knows vilakṣaṇa. That is because the awakening mind is at the site of the cakra of emanation. That is the meaning of the syllable ra, located in the cakra of emanation, endowed with unsupported limbs and vilakṣaṇa.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable ha. The syllable ha is "the most excellent of the supreme." It has the form of the aspect of khakhvamukha. It remains, fully distinguishing the meaning that has divided into two. For all, it brings to maturation the bliss that holds boundless joy. It also provides the cause for the supreme to arise elsewhere.

At that time the sign called "throbbing" arises. From that sign one knows the first joy. That is because the awakening mind is at the site of the neck of the jewel. That is the meaning of the syllable ha, located at the site of the neck of the jewel, endowed with throbbing and joy.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable syaṃ. The syllable syaṃ is "the other supreme." Or else, it means the vessel of the Buddha jewel. It is not that itself; therefore it is "other." It fully distinguishes the meaning that has divided into two. It apprehends desirable and undesirable things. It also provides the cause for the nonapprehension of all phenomena. At that time the sign called "agitated breathing" arises. From that sign one knows supreme joy. That is because the awakening mind is at the site of the inner forehead. That is the meaning of the syllable syaṃ, at the inner forehead, endowed with agitated breathing and supreme joy.

Now I explain the meaning of the syllable va. The syllable va is the core of the tip of the secret jewel. Or else, the core itself is the vessel of the Buddha jewel, very soft, subtle, intense, and not coarse: this means the center of the lotus of syaṃ. As soon as it arrives there, the awakening mind abides, fully distinguishing the meaning that has divided into two. It also provides the cause. Mounted on the life wind, it goes into the core of the wisdom consort so that a buddha may arise. At that instant the sign called "luster" arises. From that sign the yogin who knows the inner touch of the joy of cessation knows the time. This is the moment at the time of the joy of cessation. That is because the awakening mind is within the crest of the vajra.

In that place one brings to mind the syllable kṣa, the gnosis of emptiness that is the essential nature of glorious Vajrasattva. Because there is no further going, when the syllable kṣa is within the center of the precious secret lotus of one's own heart, the sign called the "heat" of stopping the gnosis wind arises. To find from that sign, through the kindness of the guru, the joy of intrinsic nature, unborn, unceasing, self-aware, and inexpressible: that is its meaning. That is the meaning of the syllables va and kṣa, within the center of the secret lotus of one's own heart, endowed with heat and the joy of intrinsic nature.

This, the meaning of the verse "Then the secret to be explained," Prajñāśrī wrote down as this secret, through the kindness of the excellent guru, as a reminder for himself.

Now, so that my own disciples may accomplish gnosis, I shall speak of the meditation on the ultimate awakening mind endowed with the eight syllables. First of all, in the space at the heart, within the dharmadhātu seal shaped like the letter e, from the transformation of kā and the rest comes the maṇḍala of kāli, and from the transformation of ā and the rest, the maṇḍala of āli. Above that, from the transformation of the syllable vaṃ, is a variegated lotus with eight petals, endowed with a center and anthers. In its middle one should meditate on the precious ultimate awakening mind, whose intrinsic nature is the light of the true, stainless supreme.

On the eastern petal of the variegated lotus are the syllable a, whose essence is "at that time, too," the channel called the Precious One, and likewise joy. On the northern petal are the syllable tha, whose essence is the drop, the channel called the Great Lotus, and likewise supreme joy. On the western petal are the syllable tu, whose essence is mode, the channel called the Greatly Fearsome One, and likewise the joy of cessation. On the southern petal are the syllable ra, whose essence is mere mode, the channel called the Greatly Powerful One, and likewise the joy of intrinsic nature. On the petal in the southeast, the quarter of fire, are the syllable ha, whose essence is the supreme, the channel called the Great Peak, and the moment of variety. On the petal in the southwest, the quarter of Nairṛti, are the syllable syaṃ, whose essence is the other supreme, the channel called the Greatly Intoxicated One, and the moment of maturation. On the petal in the northwest, the quarter of wind, are the syllable va, whose essence is gnosis, the channel called the Greatly Joyful One, and the moment of crushing. On the petal in the northeast, the quarter of Īśāna, are the syllable kṣa, whose essence is great gnosis, the channel called the Joyless One, and the moment of vilakṣaṇa. Because it is the purification of the letters, the joys, and the moments, it is a variegated lotus.

In The Flower Garland of Joy composed by glorious Indrabhūti, it is explained: "It faces downward, neither tightly closed nor open, and has a stem: the youthful cakra of Dharma." The Tattvasiddhi of the secret essence says: "In the space at the center of the secret heart is a red, eight-petaled lotus, opened in space, with a stem."

In the passage of the opening beneath its stem, the Holder, rasanā, and the Nonconceptual One, together with the life channel, which is shaped like a sprout from the earth, open a mouth just a thousandth part of the tip of a hair. That is the time of supreme joy. In the middle of the lotus's center is the Nonconceptual One, in equipoise; the Holder and rasanā are on the right and left. Others say, "That is the life channel of the lower part."

In The Flower Garland of Joy composed by the great lord of yogins, glorious Indrabhūti, it says: "The principal ones that enter into the life channel are three: the one that goes in, the one that goes out, and the one that makes its dwelling in the middle." Śrī Ratnavajra follows the same system as that; even so, there is a difference in the form of the chain. Regarding the Nonconceptual One, the master, the great scholar Nāropa, explained: "The life channel is body, the Holder is speech, and rasanā is mind; the Nonconceptual One itself has the nature of great bliss, free of body, speech, and mind." That single one is held to divide into three. If the life channel did not exist as the form of the body, there would be no abode for speech and mind. Likewise the Hevajra Tantra says:

Without the body, for the mind
There would be no place to dwell.

Therefore the body too is intended, because it bestows the result. In scripture it is taught: "When what lies within the jewel at the center of the secret lotus is drawn by the life wind, the lotus turns its face upward." As soon as it turns its face upward, just like the bliss of perfect delight of a princess in the full bloom of youth, one will swiftly and without doubt find the joy of intrinsic nature.

As soon as that is found, one enters upon the conduct of self-mastery, like a bodhisattva who is lord of the ten grounds. Such a one alone, in the midst of all who practice pure conduct (brahmacarya), practices pure conduct, because he practices his own pure conduct. The word "pure" means the awakening mind. "Conduct" means that one holds the a completely and does not cast it away. Therefore he is a great practitioner of pure conduct, because the awakening mind is turned upward. It is in this way that, through the kindness of the excellent guru, many yogins, King Indrabhūti and others, attained the accomplishment of the Great Seal before long.

This is the supreme secret, suchness itself.
Because I am fearful of putting it into words,
Whatever mere idle talk I have written,

The great learned ones will kindly forgive.

All of you, if you understand what has been said,
Genuine persons, with joy
Strive to grasp its meaning.
Although these are words like a child's,
They surely bestow a growing fruit all the same:
Their virtue is truly wondrous.

From the guru's instruction, I
Have tasted a little; it is not without meaning.
Nothing unprecedented has been written here:
What is there that is not seen in the tantra?

By whatever I have gained
In composing this explanation of the words' meaning,
By that may all beings, tied and bound in existence,
Be set free.

He who, supreme in revealing through signs the wondrous, hard-to-realize
Suchness, abides in equal union, whose essence is the union of intrinsic nature,
Who dwells in great bliss itself, joy expanded, foremost of heroes:
To that glorious Ratnavajra I pay homage.

How wonderful! Compiled by the king of the Śākyas, glorious Vajrasattva, great king of all the kings of tantra, lord of kings among the yoginī tantras, ocean of luminosity, the great Mahāmudrātilaka Tantra is marvelous, supremely wondrous, and great!

How wonderful! Excellent disciple of the great scholar and siddha Ratnavajra, master in the unbroken succession of accomplished lords of yogins from the great king Indrabhūti, the lord of yogins Prajñāśrīgupta is wondrous, sublime, and great!

How wonderful! In the ocean of joy that is the space of the Great Seal, the person of wisdom churned in meditation, with the six yogas as the glorious churning stick and the four explanations of the secret as the churning method; and from that churning, the fruit, the nectar of the joy of intrinsic nature, is this Eye of Joy, the clear drop: marvelous and great!

How wonderful! I, Rinchen Gyaltsen, who have touched the lotus of his feet, devoted to the welfare of others, made many requests with faith and reverence. By this stainless virtue, may all beings surely revel in their own luminosity! Supremely wondrous and great!

The Extensive Commentary Called The Eye of Joy, composed by the great master, the lord of yogins, Prajñāśrīgupta, is complete.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the great Indian abbot Prajñāśrīgupta himself and the chief editor-translator, the monk Rinchen Gyaltsen.

Translator's Notes

• The three levels of exposition named here, the literal meaning, the comprehensive meaning of all the limbs, and the essential meaning, correspond to the classical modes of tantric exegesis called akṣarārtha, samastāṅga and garbhī. The phrase rendered "the guru of the supreme king of the lords of kings" probably refers to the tantra itself, which the commentary also calls "the supreme king of lords among the yoginī tantras"; it could also be read as a royal title. Rinchen Gyaltsen is called dam pa slob dpon ma; I render "excellent master," though the final ma is unexplained and the phrase may be a slip for slob ma, "disciple." The queen's name (legs dgyes dbang mo) could not be identified with confidence and is translated by meaning; the masters Kilaripa and Koṅkana are given as the Tibetan spells them.
• The four moments named here, variety, maturation, crushing and vilakṣaṇa, are the classical vicitra, vipāka, vimarda and vilakṣaṇa; for the last, this Tibetan uses an unusual literal calque (rnam pa'i mtshan nyid), so the Sanskrit is given. The channels called the Holder ('dzin ma) and the Nonconceptual One (rtog med ma), paired with rasanā, appear to correspond to the lalanā and the avadhūtī, but their Tibetan names are not the standard ones and are translated by meaning. The lemma rendered "At that time, too" (char yang) may stand for Sanskrit tatrāpi, which would explain the gloss that it joins the syllables ta and ra. The word brta ka qualifying the vajra jewel is obscure; "tip" is a conjectural rendering. The term describing the form of the syllable ha is left in transliteration because its meaning could not be identified. "Circle of wind" renders rlung gi 'khor ba, possibly a slip for the "cakra of wind" (rlung gi 'khor lo) named just after.
• The eight syllables glossed one by one, here and in the preceding section, appear to be the syllables of the Sanskrit original of the root line "Then the secret to be explained," each assigned a meaning, a site, a sign, and a joy or a moment. "The joy of cessation" renders chad pa'i dga' ba, evidently the third of the four joys (viramānanda), and "the joy of intrinsic nature" the fourth. The author's name is read as Prajñāśrī (shes rab dpal); the gsang ba that follows is taken as "this secret," though it could belong to the name. The obscure brta qualifying the secret jewel is again rendered "tip" by conjecture. The names of the eight heart channels and the title The Flower Garland of Joy could not be identified with Sanskrit forms and are translated by meaning.
• The colophon gives the author's name, shes rab dpal gsang ba, in Sanskrit as Prajñāśrīgupta and says he took part in the translation himself, so that form is used here; the signature in the preceding section, rendered there as "Prajñāśrī" followed by "this secret," is very likely the same full name. The "four explanations of the secret" are the four levels at which the

commentary expounded the root line "Then the secret to be explained": the literal, the comprehensive, the essential, and that of intrinsic nature. The same stanza weaves the author's name (wisdom, glory, secret) into its churning imagery. The a held in "conduct" is the syllable identified earlier in the commentary with the awakening mind.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.